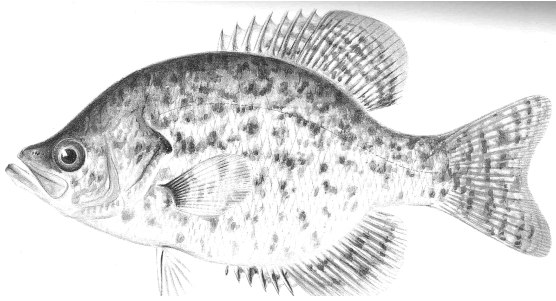


Black Crappie

Pomoxis nigromaculatus

A roaming, suspending, low-light panfish



Calico Bass; Strawberry Bass (*Pomoxis sparoides*) — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Tell it apart

Count the dorsal spines: seven or eight on a black crappie, five or six on a white crappie. The speckling is scattered and irregular, not organised into vertical bars. The body is deep, thin and silvery.

The paper mouth

The membrane around the jaw tears easily. Do not set hard and do not lift a crappie by the line — this is the fish people lose at the side of the boat.

Size here

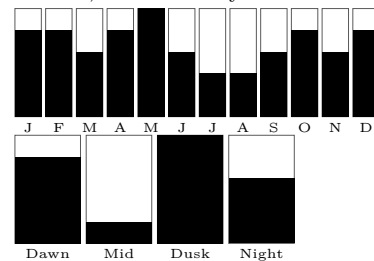
8-11 in. A 12 in crappie is a very good fish.

Spawn

58–64 °F, May, in 3–8 ft near brush, wood or the inside weed edge. Slightly earlier and slightly deeper than bluegill.

Eats

Small minnows and zooplankton. More fish-eating than the sunfish, which is why a minnow beats a worm.



Season

Time of day

Where

Pine Spot **7** (south-east bay) and **6** in spring; the edges of the mid-lake bar **4** in summer, where they suspend off the drop.

North Spots **1** and **4**, and anywhere with standing wood.

The key habit Crappie **suspend**. They roam in schools at a chosen depth over deep water, ignoring the bottom entirely. Finding the depth matters far more than finding the spot.

How

Find the depth Cast a small jig, count it down — five, ten, fifteen — and retrieve. When you get bit, remember the count and repeat it exactly.

Best bait A small live minnow under a slip bobber, *see the **slip bobber sheet***, set precisely at the depth you found. Crappie feed *upward*; set the bait slightly above them, never below.

Hookset A steady sweep, not a snap. Paper mouth.

When Dusk is the crappie hour. They also feed well in the first hour of an overcast morning and through the ice in January.

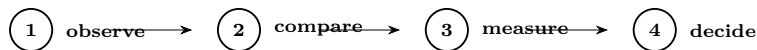
The one thing to remember

If you are catching nothing, change your *depth* before you change your bait. A school two feet below your jig will not come up for it, and a school two feet above it never sees it.

Worth knowing

They live in the middle	Crappie are among the few freshwater fish that spend most of the year genuinely pelagic — suspended in open water at a chosen depth, unrelated to the bottom. Almost every other fish in this guide relates to structure. Crappie relate to <i>depth</i> .
Boom and bust	Crappie year classes are notoriously uneven: one strong spawn can dominate a lake's population for years, then nothing. If every crappie you catch is the same size, that is why — you are catching a single year class.
They feed upward	The eyes and the upturned mouth are built to take prey silhouetted against the surface. A bait below a crappie is invisible to it. This one fact governs how you set every slip float.
Cold water suits them	Crappie feed actively at temperatures that shut a bass down, which is why they are one of the best ice-fishing targets in either lake and why January can be as good as May.
Age	A 10 in black crappie is typically four to six years old.

Prove it in hand



Ask first	Can you count seven or eight hard dorsal spines and see scattered speckles rather than bars?
Rule out	A white crappie carries five or six dorsal spines and organized vertical bars.
Measure	Close the mouth, pinch the tail only if the rule says to, and read total length against a rigid board: record to the nearest quarter-inch; do not estimate from a hand or rod blank.
Field proof	Both spine count and pattern must agree. Photograph the whole side profile and the decisive feature before release if the identification remains uncertain.

Regulations on these waters, 2026–27. Panfish: 25 per day in total, open all year, no minimum length. *These change; only the Wisconsin DNR's current publication for this exact water body is authoritative.*

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